

Chapter 24: Learning Distance

Walking home together was quiet.

Not uncomfortable.

Not easy either.

Just unfamiliar.

Jenny kept adjusting her pace without realizing it, like her body didn't know what rhythm to follow anymore.

Austin matched her anyway.

Not perfectly.

Not rigidly.

Just enough to stay beside her.

That alone made Jenny strangely aware of everything.

The sound of their steps.

The streetlights flickering.

The cold air between them that wasn't really cold anymore.

Jenny finally spoke first.

"You don't have to do this every day."

"I know."

"But you still will."

A pause.

"Yes."

Jenny exhaled through her nose.

"You're stubborn."

"I've been told."

She glanced at him.

"By who?"

"A lot of people I stopped listening to."

That made her almost smile.

Almost.

They walked another block in silence before Jenny asked,

"Don't you get bored?"

Austin looked ahead.

"With what?"

"This," she said vaguely. "Routine. Work. Me."

That last word came out too quickly.

Too honest.

Austin didn't react immediately.

Then—

"No."

Jenny frowned slightly.

"That was fast."

"It's true."

She narrowed her eyes.

"You don't get tired of anything?"

"I get tired," he corrected. "Just not of this."

Jenny looked away.

Of course he had to say it like that.

Simple.

Direct.

Dangerous.

They passed a small convenience store.

Bright lights spilling onto the street.

For a moment, Jenny slowed.

Austin noticed.

He always noticed.

"You want something?" he asked.

"No."

But she was already looking at the window display.

Snacks.

Drinks.

Small ordinary things that felt distant in this moment.

Austin stepped slightly toward the store entrance.

"I can wait."

Jenny shook her head quickly.

"I said no."

But she didn't move again immediately.

That hesitation was enough.

Austin didn't push.

He just stood there beside her.

Waiting.

Not impatient.

Just present.

Jenny finally sighed.

"...Fine. Five minutes."

That small victory made something flicker in his expression.

He didn't smile fully.

But it was close.

"Okay."

Inside the store, everything felt too normal.

Too bright.

Jenny grabbed a drink she didn't need.

Austin followed without speaking.

At the counter, the cashier glanced between them.

Jenny noticed.

Of course she did.

It felt like being observed from a distance that didn't belong to her.

Outside life watching inside life.

Jenny paid quickly.

Austin did the same.

No conversation.

No explanation.

Just shared movement.

When they stepped back outside, the air felt colder again.

Jenny held her drink loosely.

"You're quiet in places like that," she said.

"I observe."

"That sounds like a polite way of saying you judge."

Austin glanced at her.

"I don't judge you."

"That's not what I meant."

A pause.

Then—

"I know."

They walked again.

Jenny took a sip of her drink.

"You're different outside the restaurant," she said.

"I'm still me."

"It doesn't feel like it."

Austin looked at her.

"How?"

Jenny hesitated.

Then said honestly,

"You feel less controlled."

A pause.

Then softly—

"I feel less required," he corrected.

Jenny frowned slightly.

"Required by what?"

"By everything," he said simply.

That answer lingered longer than expected.

Jenny looked ahead.

"You make it sound like your life is... tight."

"It is."

"Is that why you're like that in business?"

Austin nodded once.

"Yes."

Jenny considered that.

Then said quietly,

"You don't have to be like that with me."

That made him look at her for a moment.

Longer than usual.

Then—

"I know."

A pause.

"But I don't know how to stop yet."

Jenny nodded slowly.

That, at least, was honest.

They reached her street sooner than she wanted.

Jenny stopped walking.

Austin did too.

The space between them felt smaller now.

Not physically.

Emotionally.

Jenny turned slightly toward him.

"This is me," she said.

"I know."

A pause.

Then she added,

"You don't have to wait every time."

Austin shook his head slightly.

"I want to."

Jenny sighed.

"You keep saying that like it's simple."

"It is simple," he said. "Just not easy."

That made her pause.

She looked at him carefully.

"...You always talk like that."

"Like what?"

"Like you've already decided something."

Austin met her gaze.

"I have."

Jenny frowned.

"And what is it this time?"

A beat.

Then quietly—

"That I'm not stepping away from you."

Silence.

Jenny felt that sentence settle deeper than she expected.

Not heavy.

Not alarming.

Just... steady.

She looked away first.

Of course she did.

Then she said quietly,

"You're going to scare people with that kind of certainty."

Austin nodded once.

"Maybe."

A pause.

Then—

"But not you."

Jenny looked back at him.

"...Why not me?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Then softly—

"Because you're already here."

That landed too simply.

Too truthfully.

Jenny didn't know what to say to that.

So she just stood there.

And for the first time...

"after" didn't feel like distance anymore.

It felt like proximity she hadn't fully agreed to yet.

But wasn't stepping away from either.